

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 20



CHAPTER 20



BOOK SAILING

A month later they had weathered the Roaring Forties of the North Atlantic. The crew had begun to be sailors. The last poor lubber had got his sea legs. Fingers that had bled on the halyards were healed, and black with tar. Every man could hand, reef, and steer. They could loose the guns and get ready for action; not so smartly by half as the crew Lem Harvey had trained — but they could do it.

The *Astrea* was her old self again. Dingy decks were holystoned white, and the rigging was taut, tarred, and dressed in its chafing gear.

But a sullen mood hung over the ship, like an evil mist over a swamp. Even when he was below deck, in his cabin working, Nat could feel hatred staring at the back of his neck, as though an animal stalked him in the night.

Lupe was the worst of the crew, because he smiled. A slim, swarthy young fellow, Lupe moved softly as a cat, and purred when he spoke.

"We can rest easy," Prince had said, "until the Cape."

Nat wondered what Prince would say if he knew how his supercargo felt about Lupe — that it wasn't quite safe to turn your back on him. Was it imagination, Nat wondered, or was Lupe always watching him? Did Lupe follow him at night when he was on deck taking sights?

For two weeks now, he had had that feeling of someone behind him. Twice, when he'd been standing on deck in the darkness, he'd swung about quickly, as though searching for a star in another direction. But he had seen no one.

Though tonight promised to be a good one for taking a lunar, Nat worked stubbornly at his checking of Moore's tables. Once he thought he heard his door open. He started, wheeled, and broke out in a cold sweat. This had to stop! He slammed Moore's book shut, picked up

his sextant and slate, and went topside. Deliberately, he went forward, beyond the waist of the ship, and stood at the larboard rail, facing the water. I'll stand here, he told himself, till I get over being a fool!

He didn't know how long he'd been standing there when he felt, rather than heard, cat-soft movement behind him.

A voice purred, "Señor?"

Nat forced himself to turn slowly. "Yes, Lupe?"

Lupe's teeth flashed white. He held out one brown hand. Across the palm lay a knife. "Do not stop me, what I say, señor. I say it quick, or I lose the nerve. Two weeks — maybe three — I try to get up the nerve."

So Lupe had been following him. Nat said again, "Yes, Lupe?"

"I want to ask you, señor — could we trade the — the — know-how?"

"The know-how?"

"I want to learn the — the — navigation. I teach you to throw the knife — you teach me the navigation, eh?"

Nat began to laugh, then stopped suddenly when he saw the smile stiffen on Lupe's face. "Forgive me, Lupe. But the idea of my learning to throw a knife — it just struck me funny."

"But you could, señor! And it is a good thing to know! Also, I teach you to sing the *serenatas*!"

Nat only smiled this time. "That's funnier still — me singing a serenade."

"No, no! señor! You could do it! Then you win any señorita in the world! First — the knife! Your rivals — *pouff!* They are gone! Then the *serenata*. Ahhh! The lady — she is yours! You want to get married, don't you, señor?"

"I was married, Lupe. My wife — is dead."

Lupe's smile vanished. His eyes widened. "You win the lady? No *serenata?*"

"No *serenata.*"

“Por Díos! How you do it?”

This time Nat didn't even try to stop laughing. “It's all right, Lupe. I'll be glad to teach you navigation. Tell me — how much mathematics do you know?”

“The — the — numbers?” Lupe's smile flashed again. “Very quick! I count on my fingers! Add-up! Take-off! That's good, eh?”

“Well, it's a start,” Nat admitted. “Addition and subtraction come first.”

“Then you teach me?”

“Er — what else do you know about numbers?”

Lupe’s smile faded again. “Just add-up, take-off, señor. There is more? I cannot learn the navigation?”

“Addition and subtraction . . . Let me think, Lupe . . .” Nat took a turn on deck. “If we had logarithmic tables of all the trigometric functions, you could work any problem in navigation with nothing but addition and subtraction.”

“Log tables? I make them,” Lupe promised, “with the wood!”

“No, no, Lupe. They aren’t that kind of tables. These tables are just lists of numbers. I could figure them out, all right . . .”

“You do that, señor? For Lupe?”

“On one condition,” Nat promised.

“Anything, señor! I teach you magnificent *serenatas*! You have the world at your feet! You can’t fail!”

“Is that how you won your wife, Lupe? With serenades?”

Lupe sighed. “No, señor. She not marry Lupe. Her brothers — they are first mates. They say she cannot marry Lupe. Cannot marry a man before the mast.”

Nat took another turn on deck until he was sure he could keep from smiling. He faced Lupe again. "I'll teach you on one condition, Lupe — that all the foc's'le studies with you."

"Por Díos! But why?"

"Because it's easier to teach a dozen men than one man. How about it, Lupe? You think you can persuade them?"

For a moment Lupe frowned. Then his slow smile stretched again. He looked at his knife. He purred, "Yes, señor. They do it. They do anything for Lupe." He prowled away and disappeared in the shadows.

The next day, during the dog watch, Nat began. The men worked hard; Lupe saw to that. But Nat worked harder. The tables he figured now were longer "than main to bowline." And explanations that had worked for other crews were still too hard for these men to grasp. So they worked — across the equator, to the Cape, and into the Indian Ocean they slaved — Nat and the men before the mast.

Mr. Towsen, the petulant second mate, came to Nat's cabin one night. "Mr. Bowditch, just what are you doing with the foc's'le?"

"Teaching them navigation."

Mr. Towsen's lip curled. "How much can they learn?"

Nat laid aside Moore, and spread the logarithmic tables he was making. "When these are done, every man of them will be able to work a lunar."

Mr. Towsen flushed, then whitened. "What kind of discipline will you have on this ship? Teaching the hands something your officers can't do?"

"No reason you can't learn it, too," Nat told him. "You're just as bright as Lupe — I think. Now, if you'll excuse me . . ."

Mr. Towsen stamped out. Nat went back to checking Moore's tables. At last he muttered in disgust, slammed the book shut, and went to Prince's cabin. "I'm through with Moore! Do you know how many errors I've found — so far? Eight thousand!"

Prince stared. He said it was impossible.

"I can prove it, point by point! Do you want me to get my figures and —"

Captain Prince said *no* — with trimmings. He'd take Mr. Bowditch's word for it. "So, Mr. Bowditch, what now?"

“I’m going to write a book of my own. And it’s going to have three things these books don’t have. First, the tables will be correct! Second, every sea term, every maneuver, everything a man needs to know, will be explained in words any able seaman can understand. Third, I’ll put in tables — so that any seaman can solve problems in navigation — even if he has to count on his fingers to add!”

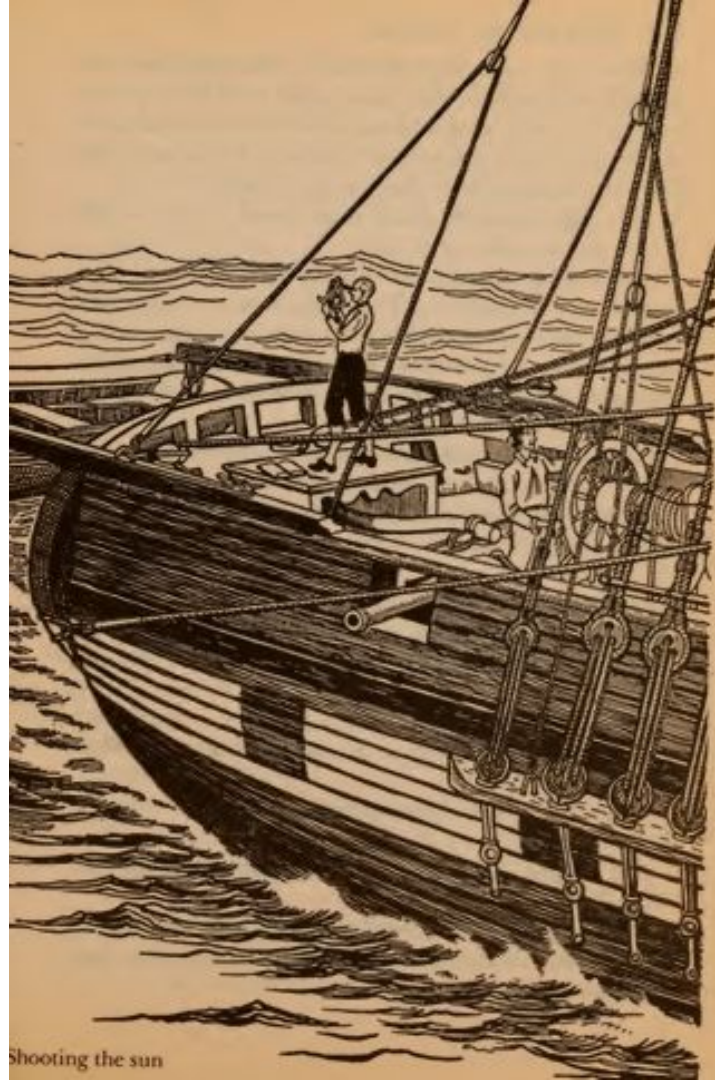
Captain Prince thought it was the wildest idea he’d ever heard. He said so — with more trimmings. “Even if you could do it — which I doubt — it would take you the rest of your life — if you lived that long!”

"I can do it," Nat roared. "I'm doing it now! If I can teach Lupe to take a lunar, I can do anything!" He stopped. Silence echoed in the cabin. He'd been yelling again.

Captain Prince stared at him for a count of ten. "Carry on, Mr. Bowditch."

"Aye, aye, sir." Nat went topside. Tonight was going to be a good time to start teaching the foc's'le to take lunar observations.

By the time the *Astrea* reached Sunda Strait, Nat had made good his threat to Mr. Towsen. He had taught the crew to take lunars, and Mr. Towsen too. The second mate had fought the idea like a harpooned whale, but he had had to learn, in self-defense.



shooting the sun

When they anchored off Batavia, Nat stretched and grinned with relief. They had sailed with a sorry crew and arrived with able seamen — with very able seamen! Smiling, he went ashore with Captain Prince and Mr. Cheevers to bargain for their cargo of coffee.

Two days later the three men stared at each other. There was no coffee to be had.

A British captain gloated over them, and made polite sounds of sympathy. “Too bad — your voyage for nothing. An expensive mistake. If you’d sailed with a cargo, you could sell that. But — you sailed in ballast, didn’t you? Nothing but specie. And now — nothing to buy. Really too bad.”

Captain Prince said there was always Manila.

The British captain looked even more pleased and sounded more sympathetic. "The monsoons, my dear fellow. Perhaps you don't know about them? Steady as the trade winds — excepting that they do vary with the seasons. Just now, if you tried to make Manila, you'd be sailing in the teeth of the northeast monsoon all the way. One doesn't sail to Manila this time of year. It just isn't done."

They returned to the *Astrea*, a grim trio. Charlie felt their mood as they sat down to mess. Dishes rattled when he served them.

“Too bad,” Mr. Cheevers said, “that our trip has failed.”

Nat banged his fist on the table. “It hasn’t failed! We can still go to Manila!”

Mr. Cheevers lifted an eyebrow. “Fighting head winds all the way? That, my *fine-figured* friend, would take some navigating!”

Nat snapped, “So we navigate it!”

Prince stiffened. His eyes narrowed. His glance flicked from Mr. Cheevers to Nat and back again. “Mr. Cheevers, how soon can we be ready to sail? To Manila?”

Again Mr. Cheevers stared at his captain and stuttered, "But — but — sir — the head winds —"

"*Mr. Cheevers!*"

"Aye, aye, sir!" With a wild look in his eyes, Mr. Cheevers went on deck.

Nat scrawled a quick note to Polly and sent it to a ship that was weighing anchor for home. They were going on to Manila, he told her, so they'd be a little longer getting home. A good trip so far. A fine crew. He smiled a little as he wrote that. But, after all, they were a fine crew now, weren't they?

On deck that night Charlie approached Nat. "Mr. Bowditch, sir — the monsoon — it's blowing the wrong way now?"

"Yes, Charlie."

"And we'll be — uh — tacking against the wind? Zig-zagging back and forth? Like we did for a little while, coming around the Cape?"

"Yes."

"All the way to Manila?"

"All the way."

"We — we'll do it all right, sir?"

"Of course," Nat told him. "It's a simple matter of — We'll do it, all right."

Day after day the *Astrea* moved in a crazy zigzag. Once she'd sailed from Sunda Strait to Manila in fifteen days. No making it in fifteen days this time. December ended;

January came and passed; February began. Eight long weeks out of Batavia the *Astrea* anchored in Manila Harbor.

The *Phoebe*, from Boston, was anchored nearby. Her master, Captain Hudson, came on board the *Astrea* to ask news of home. "And how was it around the Horn?"

"We came by the Cape," Prince told him. "Stopped in Batavia; no coffee there, so we came on to Manila."

Captain Hudson stared. "Not in the teeth of the monsoon?"

Prince shrugged in an offhand way. "Why not?"

"But — but — no f — I mean, no man — "

Prince smiled. "*No fool tries to sail in the teeth of the monsoon?* Is that what you meant?"

"Well, yes," Hudson admitted. "I mean — the navigation. You'd have to have a man who could work lunars — "

Prince shrugged again. "What's so hard about lunars? Every man in my crew can work a lunar."

Hudson's face was blank. Then he laughed, "Come on, tell me. How did you do it? Just sheer blind luck?"

Prince said, "I'm not joking. Ask any man on board."

Charlie, who was nearby, straightened and cleared his throat.

Prince nodded. "Go ahead, Charlie. Tell Captain Hudson how you calculate a lunar."

"Aye, aye, sir!" Charlie stiffened, stared straight ahead and rattled off the formula. "That's the way we do it, sir. It's better than waiting for the moon to oc-cult a star." He looked at the bewildered Captain Hudson. He added helpfully. "*Oc-cult* — that means *cover up*, sir."

Captain Prince had a sudden coughing spell.

A British ship hailed the *Astrea*. Captain Willoughby came aboard. He, too, wanted to know how it was around the Horn.

Captain Hudson began to enjoy himself. “They just arrived from Batavia. Yes, we know it isn’t done, but they did it.”

Captain Willoughby searched their faces, as though trying to figure out the joke. “You mean you have a man who can work lunars?”

Captain Hudson laughed. “One man? They have a crew that can work lunars! The cabin boy just explained it to me! I tell you, Captain Willoughby, there’s more knowledge of navigation on this American ship than there has ever been before in the whole of Manila Bay!”

From across the deck, Lupe lifted his hand in a salute to Nat. His grin flashed white in his swarthy face. A smile danced in his eyes. Nat grinned back at him. A good man, Lupe.

Captain Hudson grinned at Charlie and said he wished he could stay around a while to study with him, but he was just about to up anchor and clear for home. Nat scrawled another note to Polly and sent it by the *Phoebe*. They'd be a little longer getting home than he had thought when they left Batavia, he told her. A little delay on the trip to Manila. But everything was fine. They should make it home by September, if all went well.

It was September when they sailed smartly into Boston Harbor, every man an old salt, the *Astrea* stripped of her chafing gear and gleaming with fresh paint and varnish.

When they paid off the crew, Lupe reached a calloused hand to wring Nat's fingers. "Señor, you are one guy!

Ever you sail again, you send for Lupe, eh?"

"I doubt if I will," Nat told him. "I think I've swallowed the anchor."

Two weeks later, Captain Prince and Nat were on the road home. The first people they saw in Salem were Amanda Harvey and her brother Zack. Nat hailed them, stopped the horses, and got out to greet Amanda. "What's the news from Lem — your book sailor, Amanda?"

Amanda began to cry, and Zack hurled a string of curses. Book sailing had cost Lem's life. The *Betsy* had gone aground — because of book sailing. "Talk to Tim Yates," he sneered. "He's the only one that survived. He'll tell you about book sailing! Come on, Amanda!" He grabbed her arm, and shoved the sobbing woman along the street.

Nat got the story from Tim Yates when they reached Essex. Tim did not rage as Zack did. But what he said cut almost deeper. A mistake in Moore had wrecked the *Betsy*.

“It seems Moore had figured 1800 was a Leap Year. So he had the calculations for the moon off. Seems like an awful little mistake in a book makes a big mistake in miles. That’s what I heard the mate say when we was trying to get off the reef. I don’t understand much about it. Don’t want to, I guess. You see, Mr. Bowditch, if he hadn’t been depending on the book, he’d have been sounding. Log, lead, and lookout. That’s the way to sail. We depended on the book, though. So we went aground. When we saw we couldn’t get off, and we was going to break up, we tried to run the boats in, we did — through the surf. But it was dark as the hold in a storm. We couldn’t watch out for rollers. We couldn’t see the

rocks. When I come around, I was the only one there.”

Nat said, “You’d have been safer heading straight out from shore.”

“Yeah,” Tim agreed. “I guess that ought to be in a book, too.” Then he flushed. “I didn’t mean that like it sounded, Mr. Bowditch. But — but — a book ain’t no good. I wonder if that’s what happened to your brothers, too? Book sailing?”

Nat wet his lips. “My brothers?”

Hab and William had both been lost, Tim told him. He said again he was sorry, and shuffled off.